Russian Ark

After Sokurov

I

I opened my eyes [1] to settle the shifting kaleidoscope of the darkness, [2] but I understood nothing. [3]

I would be astonished to find myself in a state of darkness. [4] I had only the most rudimentary sense of existence, [5] as if I were dreaming. [6] I knew that I was [7] the victim of an accident, [8] but where I could not remember. [9] People began to run. [10] But I could not remember the end of the dream. [11]

I will look and listen. [12] Then they start and tremble, they call us by our name, and as soon as we have recognised their voice the spell is broken. [13] I don't remember that. [14] It lay like scales upon my eyes and prevented them from registering the fact that the candle was no longer burning. [15]

Suddenly I heard something [16] from the adjoining rooms through the walls, voices, the jingle of glasses and teaspoons. [17] They've got to collect their luggage and so on. [18] How late she is! [19] Close the door, somebody. [20]

I do not know why, but I followed him [21] with marked and constant suspicion. [22]

II

She opened the door and stepped across the threshold, [23] passing among men and women who were entering. [24] Can't you hurry up? [25] The count, who knew everyone in society, leaned over and spoke to her. [26] 'It's just because I do know you that I ask you to come to-morrow,' said the girl, laughing. [27]

But where am I? [28] A murmur ran through the crowd. [29]

For a moment the crowd stood still, but then it made another rush forward. [30] Take the whole of the nineteenth century. [31] They all seemed dissatisfied and uneasy. [32]

I did not know which way to turn. [33] That hesitation lasted only an instant. [34] The count and countess did not know where they were and were very anxious. [35]

No one paid any attention to me. [36] She did not notice him. [37] That's simply a farce, that's simply a sham. [38] In fact, man is a comical creature; there seems to be a kind of jest in it all. [39] He did not know why, but he felt a foreboding: [40] another person dressed in black. [41]

He bowed and went away. [42]

I felt afraid of being left alone, [43] following him just close enough to keep him in sight. [44]

III

I said to him in an undertone: [45] Where are we? [46] I suffer when I see that a man isn't quite sufficiently refined, or delicate, or polite. [47]

And it seemed again as if he were listening intently to his own voice. [48] But I assure you I'm a Russian. [49] I shall explain it to you in your own language and you will understand better: [50] Us here--you and myself--all Russian folk who may happen to be in these parts. [51]

Remember that we are in a strange land. [52] He was a disappointed man. [53] I had nearly lost my way. [54]

During the early days of our acquaintanceship he regarded me with marked and constant suspicion. [55] Yet they remained incomprehensible, like the Truth written in a foreign tongue. [56] And nobody could explain how it had happened. [57]

"Pray continue," I said to my fellow traveller. [58] I cannot understand what is happening. [59]

Still engaged in this manner, suddenly I heard something rustle outside the door. [60] You know, my friends, let's go in; it's evening now. [61] And can you explain this? [62] And so we, too, must part. [63] Let's go somewhere together! [64]

What was the way? [65]

Curiosity, however, prevents me, and I continue listening to the strange, arresting dialogue. [66]

He listened awhile in silence, without moving. [67] His expression changed as though he had two different faces. [68] Let the past remain the past. [69]

IV

I should kill thee again, were I only to consult my anger. [70]

Their trembling silence assured me that they were all subject to my will. [71] The officers of state stood around my throne in timid servility, watching for my glances. [72] I saw the king. [73] On either side, on slightly raised ground, stood many women in the most charming and magnificent clothes. [74]

The deepest silence prevailed in this assembly; [75] there one may whisper in conversation. [76]

I had often read of some great services done to princes and states, and desired to see the persons by whom those services were performed. [77] You are ashamed to be called great through being feared and unloved. [78] Another exclaimed: he has enriched the State, expanded trade at home and abroad; he loves the sciences and arts, and encourages farming and crafts. [79] Distorted looks and glances around betrayed the sudden arrival of terror and approaching disaster. [80] Sighs could be heard, piercing heralds of grief; and a groan, restrained by the presence of fear, was already beginning to rise. [81]

Then I continued: let us go, [82] without deigning to look at him. [83]

We shall follow you. [84] The guards who surround them and watch day and night with a hundred eyes forbid me entrance. [85] Saying this he went away like the rest. [86] My clothes, so brilliant, seemed stained with blood and soaked with tears. [87]

V

Why, for ever so long I shouted and shouted to you! [88] What was the way? [65]

All Russia is our orchard. [89]

In a flash I would traverse and surmount centuries of civilisation; [90] you and I go together. [91]

Well, I saw one. [92] We must stop admiring one another. [93] The most difficult and the most exalted love is--cruelty. [94] How cruel men are. [95]

There was no justification. [96] There is no better thing for a man to do than to delight in life and in the beauty of all things living. [97] That is called execution. [98]

He slowly walked along the corridors and staircases covered with red carpet, [99] unconsciously imitating the movements of his comrades. [100] Still they couldn't see a sight of him anywhere; [101] they must have gone home by another way. [102] And you said there was going to be a party. [103] The direction of Hell is always the easiest. [104]

I was born in Petersburg, a chilly, lazy place. [105] He had mastered several European languages and could easily pass for a German, a Frenchman or an Englishman. [106] And I say it's difficult to argue with you, my masters! [107]

On the stairs I begin lighting match after match, until I find a candle. [108] "Watch your feet carefully," once more he cried. [109] He outstretched his hand just as slowly, [110] and relief was felt at once. [111] I only wish I were a little steadier on my feet. [112]

Do you remember what this room is? [113]

He stood there as though he were listening to something. [114] Don't I hear music? [115]

I don't remember that. [14]

VI

One of the servants opening the door, I bent down to go in; [116] I stooped lower than her knees. [117] There one may whisper in conversation. [76]

My master observed the whole performance with great signs of curiosity and admiration. [118] The words shifted into new places; [119] a crowd of people pressed about the door, and there were still more in the house. [120] Or with music and singers, organ and bagpipes together, or with boxers and dancing, I amuse my spirit. [121]

These praises appeared true to my mind, because they were accompanied by the outward signs of sincerity. [122] Or beside the banks of the Neva, I amuse myself at night with horns and the rowing of daring oarsmen. [123] For, instead of a long train with royal diadems, I saw in one family two fiddlers, three spruce courtiers, and an Italian prelate. [124] How curiously he repeats to you all that the world knows! [125] But nothing equalled the pleasure of self-approval as I gave my orders. [126]

You know, Felitsa, the rights of both human beings and kings. [127] Keeping customs and ceremonies, you do not play Don Quixote. [128] My master observed the whole performance with great signs of curiosity and admiration. [118] The officers of state stood around my throne in timid servility, watching for my glances. [72]

Neither did they at all scruple, while I was by, to discharge what they had drank. [129]

Some natural necessities required me to get down; [130] I trembled. [131] Today I rule myself, and tomorrow I am a slave to whims. [132] Everyone attended to the feeling of my soul. [133]

Where everything presents luxury to me, and draws my thoughts towards pleasure, [134] poetry is dear to you, pleasant, sweet and useful, like delicious lemonade in summer. [135] Their trembling silence assured me that they were all subject to my will. [71] You insult no one. [136] Where has everything that delighted you gone? [137]

We shall follow you [84] to the sound of a sweet-voiced harp, where a little breeze scarcely breathes. [138] Nothing could compare with the brilliance of my clothes. [139]

Show us the way to the celebration you have prepared, I said to the organiser of entertainments. [140]

The guards who surround them and watch day and night with a hundred eyes forbid me entrance. [85]

VII

Some of the Piranesi views of Rome? [141]

I found myself in [142] a beauty no words can express. [143] The man answered that he knew nothing about them, that he had made a faithful copy. [144] I have returned to my city, familiar to the point of tears. [145] My disappointment was immense. [146]

To be original means to violate the law of equality. [147] I found myself in a big hall girdled at half its height by a gallery. [148] Then I again began examining the wall-paper: every spiral, silvery flower, square and line--and never imagined that I knew my room so well. [149] He wished the details of the incident to remain vague. [150]

He would remain almost impolitely silent, and would then make amends by furnishing (if he could) some fact or other about the gallery in which the picture was hung, or the date at which it had been painted. [151] Sweetly smells the earth in Italy after rain, and each of her islands has its own peculiar aroma. [152] I found myself in [142] a beauty beyond dreaming. [153] In the winter there were two hundred degrees of frost in Petersburg. [154]

I went over to [155] porcelain vases and flowered tea-sets. [156] All their furniture is 'Empire'! [157] I can think of nothing more devastating, more utterly smug than that hideous style--cabinets covered all over with swans' heads, like bath-taps! [158] I seem to remember [159] Napoleon's invasion of Russia. [160] Pray permit me to continue what I was saying. [161]

He simply sat down as comfortably as possible; [162] I was born in Petersburg. [163]

We're going to Moscow. [164] Everything in Moscow was flowering then. [165]

I seem to remember your face a little. [166] And relief was felt at once. [111] My friends, my dear friends! [167]

VIII

Let us make one another's better acquaintance. [168] I suffer when I see that a man isn't quite sufficiently refined, or delicate, or polite. [47]

I am a doctor with a large practice, and many patients to visit. [169] The day had been so ordinary; [170] my friends, my dear friends! [167]

You are to get up. [171] Well, you've come, glory be to God. [172] Let's sit here together and say nothing. [173]

You are not a doctor, I suppose? [174] Spending ten years under the vow of silence? [175] I know that I stood still, [176] wondering and waiting for his answer: [177] nobody answered. [178]

Oh, the smell of it! [179] They still smell… of a dead body. [180]

They are all serious, they all have severe faces, they all talk about important things. [181] Somehow I seem to remember your face; but I cannot place it. [182] What, you've been in the room quite a time? [183] An hour ago I was alone. [184]

How much thought and sense of beauty there was in them all! [185] I want a rest. [186] Let's sit here together and say nothing. [173]

He was silent again, [187] behaved freely with him and said what he meant. [188] Then let me look at it. [189] I've poured out a whole bottle of scent to-day and they still smell… of a dead body. [190] I don't know what to think about it. [191]

IX

And in particular, there uprose before me a picture strange indeed. [192]

They still smell… of a dead body. [180] Is it possible that this is Death? [193] And yet you say--you reproach me! [194] Well, your face is familiar to me. [195] I don't know what to think about it. [191]

I have seen them somewhere before. [196] What a passion for works of art, what anxiety to give pleasure to artists! [197] In a flash I would traverse and surmount centuries of civilisation: [90] the chain of the hours, the sequence of the years. [198] They had been there, they had stood, they had spoken--and suddenly they had gone. [199]

He would be extremely precise about the recipe for a dish, the dates of a painter's birth and death, and the titles of his works. [200] Even the cats forbear to squall. [201] After the dark autumns and the cold winters, you're young again, full of happiness, the angels of heaven haven't left you. [202] Do you know the meaning of that? [203]

He would have liked to be able to examine the picture on the spot, [204] as though something were wanting, or discordant, or superfluous, or bizarre. [205] How much these walls have seen! [206]

Lord, Lord be merciful to me, forgive me my sins! [207] Why are you offended! [208] Again, to my annoyance, the dialogue is interrupted. [209]

Think of listening to Wagner; [210] their rudeness offends me, it angers me. [211] I know most things, and ought to be listened to with attention. [212] Your knowledge of life and men is grossly deficient. [213] Why is a doctor needed? [214]

And so we, too, must part. [63] He hardly looks like a man of fashion. [215] There is very little German left in me, unless perhaps it is the patience and the obstinacy with which I bore you. [216] Whereupon, setting nose to nose, the pair plunged into a quarrel still more heated as they expounded in simple, but often curiously apposite, language opinions intelligible to themselves alone. [217]

What's the use of arguing! [218]

To speak plainly, we Russians are sheer barbarians. [219]

I seem to remember [159] its paintings, its statues and its silence. [220] Let's be quiet sooner. [221]

X

And now see what beauty and joy and comfort the hand of man has wrought! [222]

I felt a smile spread over my face. [223] In clay, marble, and bronze he wrought bodies of gods and men, and such was their beauty, that people called them immortal. [224] I seem to remember your face a little. [166]

My dear, kind, good mother, my beautiful mother, I love you! [225]

I should have married you. [226] At that time there lived in Rome a renowned sculptor. [227] Now that past rose up before him--living, fair, and joyful as in all likelihood it never had been. [228]

What a passion for works of art, what anxiety to give pleasure to artists! [197] My mind loses itself in recollections: [229] those far distant days which, at the moment of waking, seemed present. [230] I think I talked very well [231] with a diplomatic adroitness. [232] We do not seem to understand each other. [233]

The good angel of certainty had made all the surrounding objects stand still. [234] Where now is the leader of men who could draw his fellows in his train with so much care and skill and authority? [235]

As if I were dreaming. [6]

Possibly that happened in a dream, though I cannot be sure. [236] Certainly I was now well awake. [237]

The passenger said nothing more, but retreated quietly, and with short strides, [238] with marked and constant suspicion. [22] My soul is full of inappeasable regrets. [239] How you charm away my sorrows with your sincerity and goodness! [240]

I think I talked very well. [231] I noticed that his accent was good. [241]

XI

At that moment a young man passed by us. [242]

He bowed and went away. [42]

Pushkin best of all! [243] That's simply a farce, that's simply a sham. [38]

Dear Sir. [244]

He was struck by the change in him, [245] as if astonished at the word. [246] Oh, forgive me, forgive me! [247] I can't describe the feeling. [248] I wished to follow them, [249] did not think, but felt, about something different. [250] This is a moment I shall never, never forget. [251]

The crowd moved on again. [252] I felt afraid of being left alone. [43]

XII

Don't disturb her! [253]

She walked as I did, with closed eyes, blind. [254] He felt like saying something especially kind and caressing. [255] What was the way? [65] Are you here alone? [256] Work? [257]

She walked as I did, [258] answered quietly and thoughtfully. [259] They knew the way. [260] Let's go somewhere together! [64]

What's your name? [261] He was taken by the arms and led away, and began to stride obediently, [262] each step to be taken cautiously, slowly, silently, and with ponderous diffidence. [263] It was in silence that we walked the next ten paces. [264] My mind struggled in an unsuccessful attempt to discover where I was. [265]

One stands before those masterpieces of painting which, one imagines, one will be better able to 'take in' when one has looked away, for a moment, at something else. [266] So wonderful was this simple and peaceful picture. [267] It is curious how silly trivial little things, sometimes for no apparent reason, become significant. [268] Some children were shouting at their play. [269] He explained it to me at length with great detail, and we kept nodding our heads. [270]

He was silent again. [187] Let's be quiet sooner. [221] I will look and listen. [12]

He would be extremely precise about [271] the dates of a painter's birth and death, and the titles of his works. [272] We do not seem to understand each

other. [233] Let me remember now. [273] Nowhere could she find it. [274] This way, my dear. [275] 'Five!' the fair-headed peasant counts. [276]

I seem to remember [159] the peculiar smell of the varnish. [277] I don't want to go away. [278] It's time I went. [279]

I have found it. [280] I will look and listen. [12] Men need to learn what is real and what is unreal. [281]

Thanks for all you've said. [282] Thanks indeed to thee! [283] That is really quite a surprise! [284]

XIII

I seem to remember [159] some fact or other about the gallery in which the picture was hung. [285] What a passion for works of art, what anxiety to give pleasure to artists! [197] I could see that [286] there are the massive gilded frames which we see before us. [287]

In his uniform with broad gold stripes? [288] He was an excellent sailor, an expert shot with the revolver. [289] Speaking to me? [290]

Happiness used to wake with me every morning, and then it was just as it is now; nothing has changed. [291] The whole town would have been destroyed if it hadn't been for the soldiers. [292]

What does this mean? [293] I remember perfectly that [294] a great fire occurred. [295] Everything would be moving round me through the darkness: things, places, years. [296] Their conversation, restrained to whispers, flashed in fragments. [297]

We were looking at a picture; [298] in this room we can't see the fire, it's quiet here. [299] How many people had to work and search, how much talent and taste were needed! [300]

It's time I went. [279] No, I'm afraid not. [301] I sought to find them again as I remembered them. [302]

XIV

Meanwhile the restaurants were closing, and their lights began to go out. [303]

Ladies and gentlemen, please remember that it's only forty-seven minutes till the train goes! [304] Relief was felt at once. [305] But first we must move outside. [306]

Perhaps we'll find some way out! [307] Now that the hall-door was closed, [308] behind the door is heard a dull, staccato, incomprehensible noise. [309]

What took place by the theatre yesterday? [310] To be able to play so admirably and to realize at the same time that nobody, nobody can understand you! [311] Leave off your silly jokes! [312] I cannot understand what is happening. [59]

Oh, how the music plays! [313] I don't want to be made to cry until I get a cold in the head, and neuralgia all down my face. [314] But why on earth should it bother him? [315] And I can smile. [316]

And there are so many people in Russia, brother, who live for nothing at all. [317] Life is to be measured, not by a single hour, but by years. [318] Down here it is cold. [319]

I think there must have been some misunderstanding here: [320] something secret which he did not wish others to overhear. [321] Stand off, do. [322]

So I withdrew a little. [323] Please leave me alone. [324]

XV

Who is this young man? [325]

I do like it better. [326] Something extraordinary has happened. [327] My father belonged to the Orthodox Church. [328] Were not Christ and His Apostles also tramps? [329] We were looking at a picture; [298] I do like it better. [326]

And can you explain this? [62] Were not Christ and His Apostles also tramps? [329] I'd never read, never read at all, and I put on an expression as if I had read. [330] The human race progresses, perfecting its powers. [331] With whom are you daring to compare yourselves? [332]

Some spoke of it openly, giving precise explanations, which seemed to them plausible and clear. [333] And your hands too? [334] I will look and listen. [12] I turned away in silence, [335] thoughtfully eyed the large hands which, though inured to hard work, could also be very gentle. [336]

The wayfarer had lifted up hot dust in the highroad. [337] He was noble-hearted and gentle and wished no one evil. [338] How do you know? [339] To ask a question is easy, and to answer it may be difficult. [340]

I won't have him tormented. [341] Honestly, I'm not afraid! [342]

Leave him alone; don't bother him! [343]

We walked away side by side. [344] I seem to remember [159] the peculiar smell of the varnish. [277]

Nothing is there to be afraid of. [345] Everything seems to frighten me today. [346] The year before, at an evening party, he had heard a piece of music played on the piano and violin. [347] You are probably thinking to yourself: the

German lets himself go. [348] For money will the Germans make a Frenchman of a Russian. [349]

And in particular, there uprose before me a picture strange indeed. [192] I seem to remember [159] the dusty clothes he wore on his journey. [350] But on the other hand, they may call our life noble and honour its memory. [351]

And now see what beauty and joy and comfort the hand of man has wrought! [222] We all calmed down, and even became cheerful. [352] If he were a painter he would paint her in that attitude. [353]

XVI

Just now I behaved tactlessly, with insufficient reserve. [354]

She seemed to have guessed my thoughts, [355] spoke to it as to a confidant in the secret of his love. [356] None; only, I am curious to know. [357]

I seem to remember your face a little. [166] She turned around, [358] dancing a legato measure in a graceful, refined manner. [359] It is curious how silly trivial little things, sometimes for no apparent reason, become significant. [268] Yes, try that, and see. [360]

I had to agree. [361]

She turned around. [358] The Man rises to his feet, [362] unconsciously imitating the movements of his comrades, [100] dancing lightly where he stands. [363] We ought to learn how. [364]

All the people in the room followed every movement of the couple [365] while the unseen walls kept changing, [366] adapting themselves to the shape of each successive room that it remembered. [367]

Well, tell me everything without reserve. [368] The dialogue is interrupted. [369] It's time I went. [279] You're so pale, and beautiful, and charming. [370]

You've gone on far ahead, I won't catch up with you. [371]

Five soldiers go past rapidly. [372] They were the aeros of the Guardians. [373] My heart had been full of song, and I had heard in imagination the tune of the mazurka, but this was very harsh music. [374] I instantly recollected the colonel on the parade ground, and I felt so awkward and uncomfortable. [375]

Peering into the darkness, far ahead of him, with a fixed, strained look, [376] he outstretched his hand just as slowly. [110] I followed him, and we walked along for a long time away from the carriages. [377]

XVII

I seem to remember [159] the whiteness and rigidity of his stone. [378] Down here it is cold--I can't stand it any longer. [379]

For now I no longer recognised it, [380] while the unseen walls kept changing, [366] adapting themselves to the shape of each successive room that it remembered. [367] Do you remember our poor old room? [381] I remember perfectly that [294] a great fire occurred. [295]

Revolution would be better, because then no one would need to join in unless he liked. [382] A stranger has come up and asked to see the President of the Republic. [383] I could not say. [384]

All folk need to be supervised by an autocratic eye. [385] What do we want kowtowing to a foreign king? [386] Caution decides always that a stranger is a thief. [387]

Who are YOU in this establishment? [388] What are you doing? [389]

I had nearly lost my way; [54] to tell the truth, I don't understand it myself. [390] Go away now, they're tired. [391] To approach it is forbidden. [392] By WHOM commanded? [393] What's the use of arguing! [218]

I am feeling frightened, [394] looking for some place to hide myself. [395] Only something happened yesterday, some secret dread has been hanging over me. [396]

The door that goes into peace, into delight, into a beauty beyond dreaming! [397]

Do not leave the room; do not make a mistake. [398] The door that goes into peace, into delight, into a beauty beyond dreaming? [397]

Take care, brother. [399]

I bent my head, and entered by the open door. [400] The hall's too cold. [401]

XVIII

The walls of the room were bare. [402]

It looks as though it were done with nothing at all; [403] What has happened to it now? [404] He could not draw his breath. [405] My hands grew cold as I thought how many and how terrible they were, and how far away I was from the entrance. [406]

Come back to us! [407] He did not look at me, but answered quietly and thoughtfully. [408]

What are you doing there? [409] I bent my head, and entered by the open door. [400] I'll work and help you. [410]

But there's such a thing as common everyday politeness and gratitude. [411] What does this mean? [293] Is it possible to get a plain coffin? [412] There's a corpse here. [413] Please come here, Venez ici. [414]

The coffin [415] is to remind them of their last end. [416]

I asked an obvious question. [417] True enough. [418] The orderly rows of light pink dead bodies filled all the rooms. [419] That same evening we got up an entertainment--a sad and strange entertainment, at which, amongst the guests, the shadows of the dead assisted. [420] We know no class distinctions here. [421]

We stole up to them so skilfully and cautiously that we did not touch a corpse. [422] Unwieldily and unhealthily stout! [423] The very politeness with which he gave brief and precise answers seemed dangerous, on his lips, in his half bow. [424]

How should I know why men want to kill one another? [425] Whom do you mean by 'they'? [426] The Germans. [427] And can you explain this? [62] For you who still lag centuries behind: [428]

It seemed uncomfortable to live in cities which were cut off from each other. [429] The hour of courage has struck on our clocks, and courage will not abandon us. [430]

I have returned to my city, familiar to the point of tears. [145] To us it appeared as one endless day without any beginning, [431] sometimes dark, sometimes bright, but always incomprehensible and blind. [432] A board cracked in the next room and suddenly all became so extraordinarily still, as it is where there are many dead. [433]

Where is the corpse lying? [434] Some spoke of it openly, giving precise explanations, which seemed to them plausible and clear. [333] Wearily my mind recalls the many scores of Russian folk whom it has seen perish to no purpose. [435]

But we paid dearly for it all! [436] But we paid dearly for it all! [436] Preserve his last freedom of the spirit which could not be torn away from him: [437] Somehow I think that in those days my opinions must have been different from now--now that I have lost everything. [438]

I was wrong. [439] I don't know what to think about it. [191] I cannot understand what is happening. [59]

Whereafter the pair whispered together awhile. [440] I seem to remember [159] my dark empty rooms. [441]

XIX

On either side, on slightly raised ground, stood many women in the most charming and magnificent clothes. [74] In the glow of night lamps, [442] I could not see them. [443] You know, Felitsa, the rights of both human beings and kings. [127] Cataracts on both eyes, said the traveller, and yet you judged everything so decisively. [444]

The master gave a nod and the servant went away. [445] Keeping customs and ceremonies, you do not play Don Quixote. [128] And the simplest food is served at your table. [446] The snow fell in large flakes. [447]

The fountains, gardens, walks, avenues, and groves, were all disposed with exact judgment and taste. [448]

I could not see them. [443] Unhappy man, I cried, where are you? [449] The snow fell in large flakes. [447]

We shall follow you. [84] Without imitating your mirzas, you often go on foot. [450] The guards who surround them and watch day and night with a hundred eyes forbid me entrance. [85] The master gave a nod, [451] paid no attention. [452] Where has everything that delighted you gone? [137]

Show us the way to the celebration you have prepared, I said to the organiser of entertainments. [140] The guards who surround them and watch day and night with a hundred eyes forbid me entrance. [85] I could not see them, [443] calling for help till I was almost hoarse. [453] Make way, make way! [454]

Where is what made your life pleasant? [455] But where in the world does your throne shine? [456] It is hard to part, even for a short time, from someone we have come to need at every moment of our existence. [457]

XX

Well, you've come, glory be to God. [172]

What lovely, wonderful hair! [458] Joy entered my heart, and I longed passionately to go home. [459] He simply sat down as comfortably as possible; [162] when he could stay no longer he took leave of her regretfully. [460]

Next day she brought me in a parcel tied with pink bows and sealed with white wax, the pamphlet, a copy of which she had managed to find. [461] Did YOU write these? [462] Let me write you some verses, that you may tender them to her as an offering. [463] We do not seem to understand each other. [233] It doesn't really matter, but it's unfortunate that you can't give me any name. [464]

It's time to go. [465] I keep on waiting for something to happen, as if the house is going to collapse over our heads. [466] These tales and rumours ought not to be dismissed save with caution. [467]

The hall-door was closed. [468]

Such the memories that came back to my recollection that night. [469] In a flash I would traverse and surmount centuries of civilisation; [90] he will have no idea of the time. [470]

The scene is a large, square, lofty room with smooth, white walls and ceiling and a polished floor. [471] The pair moved as silently as ghosts. [472]

It was in silence that we walked the next ten paces; [264] a deep, trembling voice said something loudly. [473] Amongst this resplendent crowd was an ambassador. [474]

XXI

All eyes were gazing at him. [475]

No, a minister… prince… ambassador. [476] In the ballroom guests stood crowding at the entrance doors awaiting the Emperor. [477] He took no notice of them and at once forgot them. [478] And you're still the same diplomatist! [479]

What does that mean? [480] You ask his pardon? [481] He was not one of those many diplomats who are esteemed because they have certain negative qualities, avoid doing certain things, and speak French. [482] Events and time do not wait. [483]

Every face expressed respectful, awe-struck curiosity. [484] What will you see? [485] The magnificent reception room was crowded. [486] After some minutes, the gentleman-in-waiting who was on duty came into the great reception room, [487] bowing politely. [488]

The diplomatist preserved a mournful silence as he left the drawing room. [489] I suddenly realised vividly the hideous idea: [490] It was a coffin with bones inside. [491]

But for God's sake, be careful! [492] He even notices me and takes a warm interest in me. [493] Others don't notice it, but I see it. [494]

Every face expressed respectful, awe-struck curiosity. [484] You'll have to make his acquaintance. [495] Good-bye, till we meet again! [496]

I'll go away, that's what I'll do. [497] The magnificent reception room was crowded. [486] In the waiting room were tradesmen, women, and officials, looking silently at one another. [498]

XXII

The prince [499] began a speech he had prepared long before. [500]

Apart from conditions of war and law, that look established human relations between the two men. [501] From the midst of that crowd terrible screams arose. [502] In that reunion of great sovereigns we should have discussed our interests like one family, and have rendered account to the peoples as clerk to master. [503]

A speech he had prepared long before: [504] The divine mercy is inexhaustible! [505] And there in the coffin was the same face, though with closed eyes. [506] Various groups of people formed and dissolved, the coming formation and dissolution of kingdoms and displacement of peoples was in course of preparation. [507]

Then amidst a dead silence the feeble voice of the commander in chief was heard. [508] Several approving voices were heard in the crowd. [509]

This officer's audience lasted a long time. [510] The prince gave orders that no one should leave his post. [511] An entreaty for pardon. [512]

Why are you here? [513] Every one eyed him curiously. [514] Go away… go away! [515] Again he replied that he could not answer it. [516]

The hours dragged slowly by; [517] but at times it bored me fearfully. [518] He felt himself not only free from social obligations but also from that feeling which, it seemed to him, he had aroused in himself. [519]

He has splendid things. [520] There was room enough in the wide corridor for the generals to pass the three officers quite easily. [521]

I just looked in. [522] I felt then that it was not so, that I had no right to do it. [523] Every face expressed respectful, awe-struck curiosity. [484]

The servant began laying the table; [524] the guests got up and took their leave, promising to return to dinner. [525]

XXIII

Everything from the table napkins to the silver, china, and glass bore that imprint of newness. [526]

He has splendid things. [520] The officer admired it. [527] There was also much china standing on the tables, and still more was being brought in from the storeroom. [528]

Stand aside, make way, please make way! [529] Oh, this is delightful! [530]

All were silent, expectant of what was to follow. [531] The guests got up [532] and sat down at the tables prepared for them. [533] The servant began laying the table. [524]

What dinners and balls! [534] I am very much vexed that I have forgotten. [535]

Yes, I knew it long ago but had forgotten. [536] He could not resist looking at them once more: [537] the glass and china. [538] Seats were brought in and so was the tea. [539] Dear me, can I have forgotten? [540]

From there they passed into another room. [541] And how he dances. [542]

Is that their Tsar himself? [543] But it was gone forever. [544] I know, I know. [545] Allow me to indulge my fancy. [546]

Though sometimes it is a good thing to dream! [547] 'Yes, they have taken a wise decision,' he thought, 'I must remain free.' [548]

The soldiers' voices could be heard on every side. [549] 'Do you hear?' he asked. [550] No one paid any attention to me. [36] In the stalls everyone began moving about, going out and coming in. [551]

XXIV

He might talk to him at his leisure about matters of business, about the arrangements here. [552]

I seem to remember [159] a golden throne; [553] and under a gilded canopy, [554] see what beauty and joy and comfort the hand of man has wrought! [555] Only something happened yesterday, some secret dread has been hanging over me. [396] Our clothes are quite worn-out. [556] We must work, work. [557] There's less than an hour left. [558]

How much these walls have seen! [206] In a flash I would traverse and surmount centuries of civilisation; [90] their conversation, restrained to whispers, flashed in fragments. [297]

Do you hear him? [559] Yet so complete, so profound, was the stillness, that the voice seemed far away, submerged, unreal--a mere phantom of an echo, of the echo of my own voice. [560] How much suffering there is still! [561]

What did he say? [562]

I am going to report this. [563] I was at that moment [564] registering all street conversations for the Bureau of Guardians. [565] So much is this the case that in spring even the cats forbear to squall save in crushed and subdued accents. [566] He would cast about in his mind for some words that might console her, and would find only lame and useless ones. [567] He loved to feel the covers and turn over the pages of newly printed books. [568] But on the other hand, they may call our life noble and honour its memory. [351]

That, then, explains things. [569] I heard--and this was clearer than actual seeing--I heard: [570] Sometimes he caught himself listening to the sound of his own voice. [571]

We must work, work. [557] All Russia is our orchard. [89] I couldn't understand my life without that cherry orchard, and if it really must be sold, sell me with it! [572]

He listened awhile in silence, without moving. [67] I am deeply grateful to you! [573]

Somebody's come to see me. [574] And I remained alone. [575] It is not given him to foretell what each succeeding hour, what each succeeding minute, shall have in store for him. [576]

I do not know why, but I followed him. [21] Oh, what has become of my past and where is it? [577] He seems to speak with great authority. [578] I am unable any more to distinguish what is dream from what is actuality. [579]

XXV

He was so very elegant, his complexion so nice and white, his uniform so brand new. [580]

And how handsome they both are! [581] My word, I admire you! [582] As often happens in early youth, especially to one who leads a lonely life, he felt an unaccountable tenderness for this young man and made up his mind that they would be friends. [583]

Oh my friend, my friend! [584] I had a foreboding that that stain would deprive me of nine-tenths of my personal dignity. [585]

Oh, forgive me, forgive me! [247]

It was far from being the same words or the same order that reached the farthest links of that chain. [586] But his words hardly reached us. [587] I invented adventures for myself and made up a life, so as at least to live in some way. [588]

I could not even picture him before me then. [589] That is, I believe it, perhaps, but at the same time I feel and suspect that I am lying like a cobbler. [590]

I say things happen not as we plan but as God judges. [591]

But, no! I am lying. [592] I invented adventures for myself and made up a life, so as at least to live in some way. [588] If he tried, his pictures seemed incongruous and false. [593]

Though sometimes it is a good thing to dream! [547] He could not understand it. [594] I used to wriggle along in a most unseemly fashion, like an eel,

continually moving aside to make way for generals, for officers of the guards and the hussars, or for ladies. [595]

He hastened away. [596] What need to hurry? [597]

Can't you hurry up? [25] The melancholy silence that followed was broken by the sounds of the children's voices and laughter from the next room. [598]

XXVI

I feel as if I were sailing under the broad blue sky with great white birds around me. [599]

His name was called twice before he answered. [600] Some children were shouting at their play: [269] such singing and laughter and scampering about the empty rooms. [601]

She never spoke save in low tones; [602] only something happened yesterday, some secret dread has been hanging over me. [396] Even with my back I feel that shadow following me. [603] Nay; do not fret yourself, my darling, but chase away these despondent thoughts from you. [604] Nothing is there to be afraid of. [345]

You devote yourself to teaching, I, to the household. [605] We are a family. [606] I have the feeling of leaving some one I know for another quite different person. [607] I will look and listen. [12]

Now go to our boy, and watch over him; [608] already one doctor has been to attend the boy, without doing him any good. [609] I used to love my bicycle so, to walk and run. [610] I am overcome with remorse. [611]

Mother! mother, are you crying? [612] I feel so light, so free; there is a light in the distance, I see freedom. [613]

I move my armchair. [614] That doesn't matter, I can do it, you know. [615] Peer into her son's face: [616] Let's sit down here. [617]

How late she is! [19] Forgive me for that too, don't think badly of me. [618] He answered, [619] listened to his mother. [620] And I'd served tea. [621]

Stay where you are. [622] Nothing is there to be afraid of. [345]

He moved away. [623] You've gone on far ahead, I won't catch up with you. [371] Good-bye. [624]

XXVII

Seldom has it fallen to my lot to enjoy such ravishing strains as those which always greet our ears at balls given by the Man. [625]

A grand ball is in progress in the salon of the mansion which the Man has built for himself. [626] She danced gracefully around him, smiling and adjusting her skirt; [627] the whole room applauded. [628] But there aboard the liner, in the bright halls shining with lights and marble, gay dancing filled the evening, as usual. [629]

Where are they all? [630]

In vain I looked for a familiar face in this group of disconcerted men--I could not find one. [631] Somehow I seem to remember your face; but I cannot place it. [182] The dancers spread themselves over the floor again. [632] Everything seems to frighten me today. [346]

There he is! [633] I called out; [634] but I did not hear any sound. [635]

Yes; they are at home here. [636] I was afraid you might be angry with me. [637] A crowd of people pressed to the carriage doors. [638] Ah, one could listen to such strains for ever! [639]

At the first sound of the mazurka, he stamped one foot smartly, threw the other forward; [640] Bravo! [641] The colonel was just refusing to dance, saying that he had quite forgotten how; but at that instant he smiled, swung his arm gracefully around to the left. [642] It is quite a pleasure to look at them, they are so youthful and handsome. [643] As for me I not only admired, I regarded them with enraptured sympathy. [644]

In another world, [645] this is the most distinguished orchestra of the day. [646] I am quite worn out. [647] They grind out the tune and sway their heads and bodies to and fro to the rhythm. [648]

Men of his class usually began their enjoyments with a trip to Europe, India, Egypt. [649] He did everything well. [650] Ah, but never have they looked upon such brilliancy as we see here to-night! [651] I know joy will come tomorrow. [652] We'll talk to-morrow. [653]

You've so many visitors, I'm really ashamed. [654] The crowd kept moving and looked as though there were no end to it. [655] The Man rises to his feet, and dancing lightly where he stands, takes his wife round the waist, and dances with her. [656]

There he is! [633] To-day I'm quite happy. [657] You are to me now as dear and as near and as far out of reach as he was at that moment. [658]

He broke off, as if he had said all and was silent. [659]

XXVIII

Yes, you have found me. [660]

It may seem funny and silly; [661] my soul is full of inappeasable regrets. [239]

It's time to go. [465] Where are you off to? [662] What was the way? [65]

I don't want to go away. [278]

I know that I stood still, [176] wondering and waiting for his answer: [177] And if I should ask you to stay here with me? [663] They understood each other and something was firmly settled between them at this moment. [664] I don't want to go away. [278]

My life, my youth, my happiness, good-bye! [665] We do not seem to understand each other. [233] Oh, my childhood, days of my innocence! [666]

The Guests begin to depart. [667]

Servant boys [668] unobtrusively came and went, carrying up the stairways plaids, canes, valises, hand-bags of crocodile leather, and never speaking above a whisper. [669] The carriages are waiting. [670] Many ladies and gentlemen were putting on light fur-trimmed coats. [671] At dinner, you know. [672] And you said there was going to be a party. [103] The present is beastly, but when I think of the future, how good it is! [673]

He went down the stairs. [674] Who's talking so loudly out here? [675] I think it was Pushkin. [676] He had been dead. And now he is again among them. [677] Many ladies and gentlemen were putting on light fur-trimmed coats. [671]

Then they start and tremble, they call us by our name, and as soon as we have recognised their voice the spell is broken. [13]

I feel as if I were sailing; [678] the floor was still rocking beneath him. [679] I'm asleep, it's only a dream, an illusion. [680] I have found the lady. [681] Upon this the Guests resume their conversation with a sigh of relief. [682]

Please come here! [683]

Nobody answered. [178] Excuse me, may I go this way? [684] I can't go alone! [685] I have the feeling of leaving some one I know for another quite different person. [607]

You alone can understand me. [686] He saw everything--understood everything. [687] I strained my ears and listened, listened ever. [688]

They hasten to overtake their companions; [689] the din dies down a little. [690]

XXIX

The sea is there! [691]

I felt that I had been very far away: [692] there are streets, houses, a University. [693] The ocean heaving beyond was terrible, but no one thought of it, firmly believing in the captain's power over it. [694] I looked at the sky, [695] eagerly scanned the seas looming near and sinking with a thud. [696]

And the sea murmured and murmured. [697]

That same evening we got up an entertainment--a sad and strange entertainment, at which, amongst the guests, the shadows of the dead assisted. [420] A stranger in the house, with its paintings, its statues and its silence, the light--itself silent and indefinite--awakened painful thoughts in him as to the vanity of bolts and guards and walls. [698] I've got an agreement to go and look after their house. [699] The warm, luxurious cabins, dining-rooms, halls [700] shed light and joy, [701] quivered with the sounds of a string orchestra. [702]

I knew that I was [7] the victim of an accident. [8] Our existence is but a brief crack of light between two eternities of darkness. [703]

Then more rooms, glimmering mirrors, sombre closets. [704] How, on such a night as this, one remembers all that one has ever seen, and the folk that ever one has known! [705] But on the other hand, they may call our life noble and honour its memory. [351] I seem to remember [159] the chatter of an elegant crowd. [706] The floor was still rocking beneath him; [679] he slowly came back to life, to find in its suffering and in its joys a shield against the darkness of the void and the horror of the Infinite. [707]

I will look and listen. [12] Suddenly I heard something [16] from the adjoining rooms through the walls, voices, the jingle of glasses and teaspoons. [17]

And the sea murmured and murmured. [697] We must live… we must live. [708]

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